was growing. He and his advisers knew that flying over the SAM sites was a dangerous undertaking. The chances of a U-2 being shot down were assessed at one in six. As no one believed that the administration could risk having a CIA pilot captured, Secretary of Defense Robert McNamara proposed that CIA pilots be replaced with Air Force pilots: in case a U-2 plane was shot down and the pilot captured, he would say that he had been on a peripheral flight over international waters (the operation conducted by the US Air Force) and simply lost his way.[24]

Kennedy made his decision on October 10. It took another three days to train an Air Force pilot to fly a CIA U-2C plane and then for the weather to clear and make possible the dangerous flight over known SAM sites. Mission 3101, as the overflight of the San Cristóbal area was designated by the CIA, was entrusted to Major Richard S. Heyser, a thirty-five-year-old veteran of the Korean War. Heyser, who served with the 4028th Strategic Reconnaissance Squadron of the 4080th Strategic Reconnaissance Wing, took off from Edwards Air Force Base in California at 11:30 p.m. on October 13. His ultimate destination was McCoy Air Force Base in central Florida, but he would get there only after overflying western Cuba. It was supposed to be a seven-hour flight, only seven minutes of which the pilot would spend over Cuba.

Major Heyser entered Cuban airspace at 7:30 a.m. October 14 at an altitude of 72,500 feet and switched on his camera, which was capable of capturing an area up to one hundred nautical miles wide beneath the plane. Everything went as planned. No missiles were fired from below, and the SAM sites, whether ready or not, remained silent. Heyser landed at McCoy Air Force Base at 9:20 a.m. ET on Sunday, October 14. His film was flown immediately to Andrews Air Force Base near Washington, DC. It then went for development at the Naval Photographic Intelligence Center. CIA experts at the National Photographic Interpretation Center in Maryland received the film on Monday, October 15. They would begin the week with a startling discovery: John McCone had been right all along—the Soviets had deployed MRBMs on the island.[25]